

Chapter 17: Joe and the Storm

My Father

I need to tell you about my father.

Not the facts first - though the facts matter and I will give them to you. Not the timeline, the career summary, the list of accomplishments that people read at memorials and nod at without feeling anything. I need to tell you about the man. The actual human being who raised me. The one who drove me to school and picked me up from practice and sat at the kitchen table explaining things I did not yet have the capacity to understand. The one who believed - with a conviction I have only begun to appreciate in the years since he left - that the world could be made better by one man holding the line.

Joe Clokey. Born November 28, 1961. He studied at Cal Poly San Luis Obispo - not film school, not business school, but horticulture. The science of growing things. I believe he chose horticulture because film and business were things he already knew - he grew up inside them. He was raised by Art Clokey. The set was his childhood. The industry was his inheritance. He did not need a degree to understand media or commerce - those were the means to the end, not the end itself. He needed the living system that gave the means their purpose. So he studied how things grow. He never told me this. But I understood it once I started doing the same thing - studying bioinformatics instead of film or business, because the technology and the entrepreneurship were already in my hands, and what

I needed was the living system to apply them to. The pattern repeated before I recognized it.

I think about this constantly now, because everything he did for the rest of his life was an expression of that training. Not metaphorically. Structurally. Horticulture is the patient, disciplined, season-dependent work of cultivating something alive. You study the soil. You learn the conditions. You plant at the right time and you wait, and the waiting is not passive – the waiting is the work, because the gardener's job is not to force the plant to grow but to protect the conditions under which the plant grows itself. My father studied how things grow. He spent his life trying to grow something in soil that had been poisoned against it.

He founded San Luis Video Publishing and produced over two hundred educational films. Two hundred. Not blockbusters. Not viral content. Not the kind of work that makes a man famous or wealthy or the subject of profiles in industry magazines. Educational films – the quiet, necessary work of taking knowledge and making it accessible to people who need it. The kind of work that does not appear on any list of cultural influence but makes the world slightly more intelligent, one viewer at a time, the way a gardener makes the world slightly more alive one plant at a time.

He married my mom, Jora Landis. They had three children: Shasta, Sequoia, and me. Sage. The youngest. Named by my brother Shasta, like my siblings, for something that grows. A mountain, a tree, and a plant. Earth, endurance, and wisdom. Our names were not an accident. Our father studied horticulture. He named his children for the things he spent his life learning to cultivate.

He did not seek attention or platform or influence for its own sake. He was a man who worked. Who showed up. Who kept his word. Who believed that the right thing, done consistently over a long enough period of time, would eventually prevail – that the system, for all its flaws, would ultimately recognize something real when it was placed before it with enough patience and enough integrity.

He was wrong about that last part. At least in the way the world measures rightness. But I am getting ahead of the story.

The Inheritance

When Art Clokey died on January 8, 2010, the world lost a creator. Our family lost the man who had held Gumby for more than fifty years. And my father inherited a mission he did not choose and could not refuse.

Joe became president of Premavision – Clokey Productions. The studio Art had named after universal love. The company that had never been sold, never been acquired, never been handed to a conglomerate for distribution or a corporation for monetization. The thing that was still alive, still carrying the code, still encoded with *Prema*.

But alive is not the same as safe. Alive is not the same as funded. Alive is not the same as understood by an industry that had spent the decades since Art's heyday consolidating into six companies that controlled three-quarters of everything Americans saw and heard. The world Art planted into and the world Joe inherited were not the same world. In Art's era, an independent creator could still reach an audience. The channels were fewer, but the gatekeepers were less concentrated. An independent studio in Sausalito could produce content and find distribution without surrendering the seed. It was never easy. But it was possible.

By the time Joe took the reins, the channels had narrowed to the point of closure. The Telecommunications Act of 1996 had removed the caps on media ownership while keeping the government licensing structure intact. Fifty media companies became six. The gatekeepers did not just control access – they controlled the terms of access. And the terms were always the same: surrender the intellectual property, or we do not distribute. Hand us the seed, or we will not let you plant it.

My father did not inherit a business. He inherited a seed in a world of swords. And he spent the next eight years of his life – the last eight years of his life – trying to plant it in soil that refused to receive it.

The Eight Years

I am going to tell this part plainly, because it deserves plain telling. The facts are heavy enough without decoration.

Classic Media: Six Years of Nothing

Joe's first major partnership was with Classic Media. In October 2006, they announced a long-term joint venture. Classic Media would manage US and international television, film, home video, digital, and promotional rights. Tom Sarnoff – the former West Coast executive vice president of NBC, the same man who had originally greenlit *The Gumby Show* on NBC in 1956 – negotiated the deal for the Clokey side. The plan was a direct-to-video movie targeted for 2008 and an all-new television series, with Clokey Productions producing.

Six years. He worked with them for six years. He attended meetings. He flew to offices. He pitched concepts. He waited for calls that came late or did not come at all. He followed up on promises that evaporated on contact. He trusted the process, because he was a man who trusted processes – who believed that if you showed up with something real, the system would eventually recognize it.

Nothing was produced. Not a single episode. Not a single film. Not a single minute of new Gumby content. Six years of a man's life spent in the machinery of an industry that had no intention of using the machine to create anything. The machinery existed to hold the property – to sit on the rights, to occupy the space, to prevent anyone else from using the brand while deciding whether it could be monetized on the industry's terms. When the license expired on September 30, 2012, the rights reverted to

Premavision. Joe had kept ownership. But six years of potential production had been consumed. Six years of a man's finite life force had been burned in a machine that was never switched on.

In July 2012, DreamWorks Animation bought Classic Media for \$155 million. Later, NBCUniversal bought DreamWorks. The company that had held the Gumby license for six years and done nothing with it was absorbed into the corporate stack. The pattern was already visible to anyone looking: touch the property, produce nothing, absorb or be absorbed. Classic Media also bought VeggieTales at a bankruptcy auction for \$19 million - another beloved independent children's property, another creator who lost everything. They touched both properties. They produced nothing with either one.

The Jim Henson Company

After Classic Media, Joe pursued the Jim Henson Company. This should have been the natural partnership - Henson's legacy of handmade characters, of believing that craft could carry story, of understanding that the physical texture of a puppet or a clay figure is not a limitation but a language. Joe believed the Henson company would understand what Gumby was. That they would see the clay, the *Prema*, the living quality of stop-motion animation, and say: yes, this is our tradition too. Let us do this together.

In April 2015, the Jim Henson Company and Premavision announced a new full stop-motion Gumby series targeting fall 2016 delivery. This was the most faithful attempt to honor Art's vision - classic Plasticine claymation, updated designs, stories about friendship and courage. It was real. It was designed. It was ready.

It needed a co-production partner. In the language of the industry, this means someone else had to put up the money. And no one would. Not a single company in the entire children's entertainment landscape would fund a stop-motion Gumby series in partnership with Jim Henson. One of the most recognized characters in American culture, paired with one of

the most respected names in children's entertainment, and no one would write the check.

By 2015, six companies controlled virtually all children's entertainment funding and distribution. An independent co-production partner with the resources to fund a children's series essentially did not exist anymore. The consolidation had been so complete that there was no one left outside the system with the capacity to say yes. The co-production partner never materialized. The project died in silence. No follow-up announcement was ever made.

Amazon

Then Amazon. The new player. The disruptor. The company that was supposed to be different - that had the resources, the platform, the appetite for content that the traditional studios lacked. Joe pitched Gumby to Amazon.

It fell through. I do not know all the reasons. I was young. The details were kept from me, the way parents keep the weight of their failures from their children - not out of dishonesty, but out of love. Out of the belief that a child should not have to carry what the parent is carrying.

It fell through.

Papercutz Comics

A Gumby comic series launched in July 2017 through Papercutz. Three issues. Three. After six years with Classic Media, after the Henson dead end, after Amazon - three comic books, and then cancelled. Three issues is not a market test. Three issues is not enough time to build an audience. Three issues is the industry giving you just enough rope to believe the door is open before closing it again.

Gumby Imagined

In November 2017, three months before he died, Joe and my stepmother Joan published *Gumby Imagined* - a beautiful book documenting the art,

the history, the creative process behind Gumby. It was an act of love. It was also an act of record. A way of ensuring that the *why* behind the clay was written down, captured, preserved in a form the industry could not block – because a book does not need a co-production partner, does not need a network’s permission, does not need a gatekeeper’s approval.

I think, looking back, that they knew. Not consciously. Not in a way they would have articulated at the dinner table. But somewhere in the act of writing that book – of gathering the art, telling the stories, documenting the philosophy – they were building an ark. They were putting the seed in a vessel that could survive the flood they felt coming but could not name.

The book was published in November 2017. Joe died four months later.

The Weight

I want you to understand what eight years of this does to a person. Not abstractly. Not as a case study or a cautionary tale. Concretely. Physically. In the body.

Eight years of carrying a legacy you did not choose but cannot set down. Eight years of waking every morning with the weight of your father’s life’s work on your shoulders and the knowledge that you are the only person standing between that work and the people who will strip it for parts. Eight years of walking into rooms where the people on the other side of the table smile and nod and express enthusiasm and then – nothing. A call that never comes. An email that goes unanswered. A deal that was alive last month and is dead this month and no one will tell you why.

The industry never says no. That is the cruelest part. The industry says: we’re still in discussions. The timing isn’t right. We need a co-production partner. Let’s revisit this next quarter. The industry says *maybe* for six years, because *maybe* costs nothing and *no* provokes a response. *Maybe* keeps the man on the other end of the string burning his life force in hope

while the people holding the string have already made their decision and simply have not communicated it. *Maybe* is the sword's most patient weapon. It does not swing. It waits. It lets gravity and time and the finite energy of a human heart do the work.

My father was not a naive man. He understood the industry. He had produced over two hundred films. He knew how the machine worked – the meetings that led to meetings that led to nothing, the enthusiasm that evaporated between Tuesday's phone call and Friday's silence. But he believed – and this was his greatness and his tragedy – that the machine could be persuaded. That if you brought something real, something alive, something carrying more than fifty years of unbroken creative vision, the machine would eventually recognize it and say yes.

The machine does not say yes to living things. The machine says yes to products. And Gumby, as long as a Clokey was holding it, was not a product. It was a living thing. It had *Prema* in its code and a man standing over it who would not let the code be stripped out. The machine could not use it on the machine's terms. So the machine said *maybe* until the man carrying it collapsed.

The Last Conversation

A few months before he died, my father said something to me that I have carried every day since.

I was fourteen years old. I did not understand what he was telling me. I have spent every year since trying to understand it, and I am not sure I am finished.

He told me he was being affected by them the same way Jim Henson was.

Jim Henson – creator of the Muppets, another independent children's creator operating outside the corporate system – died on May 16, 1990, at the age of fifty-three. Sudden infection. Organ failure. Dead within forty-

eight hours of being admitted to the hospital. He had been in negotiations to sell the Muppets to Disney – negotiations that had dragged on, that had consumed his energy, that had placed him in the position of defending his creation's integrity against a corporation that wanted the characters without the philosophy. The deal collapsed after his death. It took fourteen years for Disney to finally acquire the Muppets.

My father saw the parallel. He saw it clearly enough to say it out loud to his fourteen-year-old son. He saw that the industry was doing to him what it had done to Henson – two independent creators of beloved children's properties, both operating outside the corporate system, both blocked by the same gatekept structure, both wearing down under the accumulated weight of a fight the system was designed to win by attrition. He connected his own experience to Henson's. He identified a "them." He named the pattern.

I do not know if he told anyone else. I do not know if he meant it as a warning, a confession, a plea for someone to hear what he was enduring, or simply the truth spoken aloud because it needed to be spoken and his son was the one in the room. I know that he said it. I know that I heard it. I know that the words passed through me the way light passes through glass – I felt the warmth but could not see the shape. I was fourteen. I did not have the frame to hold what he was giving me. The frame came later. The frame is being built now.

He was telling me that the fight was killing him. That the industry he was trying to reach was unreachable – not because it lacked the capacity but because it lacked the will, and the will was absent because the people who held the gates had their own reasons for keeping an independent, principled, uncompromisable family on the outside. He was telling me that the gap between what he carried and what the system could accept was the gap that was destroying him.

February 2, 2018

My father returned from a trip to Atlanta. He collapsed. Brain bleed.

One month. From onset to death, one month. February 2 to March 2, 2018.

The public reports said cardiac arrest. The family knows the fuller truth: it was a brain bleed that led to cardiac arrest. The brain bleed was the initiating event. The heart stopped because the brain was already failing. The man did not die of a weak heart. The man died of something that ruptured inside his head, and the heart followed because the heart follows the brain the way the body follows the spirit.

He was fifty-six years old.

Fifty-six. Art lived to eighty-eight. Joe made it to fifty-six. The thirty-two years between those numbers – the decades of life that should have been, the conversations that should have happened, the guidance I should have received, the book he should have written, the Gumby series he should have produced – that gap is something I carry in my body, not my mind. My mind can process the fact. My body holds the weight of it. The weight is in my chest when I wake up and in my shoulders when I sit down to write and in my hands when I type these words that he should be alive to read.

He died in the middle of the fight. Not at the end – there was no end. The fight was ongoing. The calls were still being made. The pitches were still being prepared. He died the way soldiers die in wars that have no front line – not in a decisive battle but in the accumulated exhaustion of a conflict that never pauses, never declares a truce, never gives the man in the field a single day when he does not have to carry the weight.

Jim Henson died at fifty-three. Joe died at fifty-six. Two independent children's creators. Both blocked by the same system. Both dead suddenly in their fifties. Both followed by the acquisition of their properties by the

corporate structure they had spent their lives resisting. The parallel my father identified months before his death held with the precision of a pattern observed, not a coincidence imagined.

I do not know, with certainty, what killed my father. A brain bleed at fifty-six is uncommon but it occurs. I know what the documented record shows: the man who held the last major independent children's IP that the corporate system wanted – an IP they had tried and failed to acquire through normal channels for over a decade – died suddenly at fifty-six. After his death, the IP was acquired.

I am not making an accusation. I am stating what is known and what is not known and letting the pattern speak for itself. My father made his own accusation, in his own words, to his own son, months before he died. He said he was being affected by them the same way Jim Henson was. I heard it. I carry it. I do not pretend to know more than I know. But I do not pretend to know less, either.

What Was Lost

I was fourteen. My brother Shasta was the oldest. My sister Sequoia was in between. My stepmother was suddenly a widow carrying the same legacy that had worn her husband into the ground, without the partner who had been carrying it with her.

At fourteen, you understand death the way you understand a foreign language you have heard but never studied. You recognize the sounds. You know that meaning is present. But the meaning has not settled into your bones. It hovers outside you, real but unreachable, and the reaching is what the years after are for. The meaning settled when I was nineteen and trying to decide what to do with my life. It settled when I was reading about the industry that ground my father down. It settled when I was twenty-two, writing a book about the philosophy that fueled a family for

three generations, and I realized I was writing it because the man who should have written it was not here to write it himself.

And then came the second loss.

In February 2022, four years after Joe's death, Gumby was sold. All of it. Premavision, Prematoy, the character, the name - film, television, streaming, consumer products, licensing, publishing. Everything Art built. Everything Joe spent his life protecting. My stepmother made the decision to sell. I was asked for my approval. I was eighteen, starting college, beginning my first year at UC Santa Cruz. I was not fully sure what was happening. I did not want to sell. But there was legal pressure - probate, the machinery of estates, the financial weight of holding intellectual property without revenue. It seemed like selling was the only option. I am still not certain that was true. I signed. And the thing my grandfather created and my father died protecting passed into the hands of a corporation.

They are now making *Gumby Kids*. Two-dimensional animation. Not claymation. No clay. No stop-motion. No philosophy of transformation. No *Prema*. The green seedling flattened into a corporate product. The thing that walked into books reduced to a brand asset. Art Clokey called Gumby "an act of love to children." What is being produced now is not an act of love. It is an act of acquisition.

I carry the wound of the sale the way I carry the wound of my father's death - not as a grievance but as a lesson. The lesson is not that we should have fought harder. The lesson is not that my stepmother was wrong or that I was too young or that someone should have seen it coming and stopped it. The lesson is structural. The lesson is that it is not enough to hold the line. You must build something that survives the holder. You must embed the philosophy so deeply into the structure that the philosophy cannot be stripped out without destroying the structure itself. The single tree, tended by a single gardener, can be felled by a single storm. The forest cannot. The seed-over-sword principle, taken to

its conclusion, demands not a better gardener but a better architecture – one that does not depend on any single person’s strength, any single person’s life, any single person’s willingness to carry the weight alone until the weight becomes too much.

My father’s death proved the principle and revealed its limit. One man, holding the line, for eight years, in a system designed to break him. The principle was right: do not sell, do not compromise, do not hand the living thing to the machine. But the implementation was fragile, because the implementation depended on a single human life, and a single human life is the most fragile thing in the world.

The Storm

This chapter is called “Joe and the Storm” because that is what my father’s death was. Not only a loss. A scattering.

The Fibonacci spiral through generations works like this: the farmer plants one seed and grows a tree. Then comes the storm. The storm destroys the tree. And the world calls this failure, loss, the end. But the storm scattered the seeds. Dozens of them. Hundreds. Across the land, into soil the farmer could never have reached alone. And many trees grow. Each generation rising and falling higher and harder than the one before. Each fall scattering more seeds than the last. Each rise reaching further than what came before it.

Art planted the seed. Joe grew the tree. The storm came and took them both. But the seeds scattered.

My father’s death was the storm that proved the old model insufficient. The old model was the single guardian, the single tree, the single man standing between the living thing and the system that wanted to consume it. That model worked for sixty years under Art and eight years under Joe. And then it failed – not because the men were weak, but because the

model itself was too fragile for the forces arrayed against it. One death. That is all it took. One death, and the sixty-three years of protection collapsed, and the property passed through probate into the hands of the people my father had spent his life keeping it away from.

The lesson is not grief. The lesson is design.

If the philosophy depends on a single guardian, the philosophy dies when the guardian dies. If the architecture requires a single protector, the architecture falls when the protector falls. This is not a failure of character. It is a failure of structure. And the response to a structural failure is not to find a stronger guardian. The response is to build a structure that does not require one.

This is what the Living Age is. Not a better tree. A forest. Not a single property held by a single family through a single line of inheritance. An open-source system, distributed across networks, encoded in biology, published on platforms that do not require a government license or a gatekeeper's permission. Something that cannot be acquired because it does not belong to any single person. Something that cannot be killed by a single death because it does not depend on any single life.

Art needed NBC's permission to reach an audience. Joe needed the industry's permission - Disney, Amazon, Classic Media, Henson, all of them. I do not need anyone's permission. The internet is the first distribution system in human history that does not require a government license. Open-source code cannot be acquired because it belongs to everyone who reads it. Biology - the living architecture at the heart of this work - cannot be controlled by a corporation because life does not answer to shareholders.

The storm scattered the seeds. The seeds landed in soil that did not exist when my father was alive. And the trees are growing now - not one tree in one place, but many trees in many places, connected by roots the sword cannot see and cannot cut.

For My Father

Dad.

I did not understand what you were telling me. I was fourteen and the words passed through me like light through glass - I felt the warmth but could not see the shape. I see it now.

You were telling me that the fight was killing you. That the industry was unreachable. That the system was not designed to receive what you were offering, and the gap between what you carried and what they could accept was the gap that was destroying you. You were telling me to pay attention, because the story was not over, because the thing you were carrying would need to be carried by someone else, and I was the one you were telling.

You were right. And you should not have had to carry it alone.

I cannot go back and carry it with you. I cannot take the weight off the heart that gave out. I cannot undo the six years with Classic Media or the co-production partner that never came or the Amazon deal that evaporated or the three comic books that were all the industry gave you for eight years of your life. I cannot stop the brain bleed. I cannot rewrite February 2018. I cannot bring you back.

But I can grow what you planted. I can take the seed - the *Prema*, the principle, the vision of a world where creators do not have to sell their souls to reach their audience - and I can put it in soil you never had access to. Soil that did not exist when you were alive. Technology that distributes without gatekeepers. Code that publishes without permission. Biology that grows without a license. A world where the sword is losing its grip and the seed is finding cracks in the pavement that were not there when you were pushing against it with everything you had.

The fight that killed you was the right fight. The principle you held was the right principle. The love you carried - principled, fierce, costly,

uncompromising – was the real thing. You studied horticulture and spent your life trying to grow something alive in an industry that only knows how to harvest. You named your children for things that grow. You held the line until the line held you and then it couldn't anymore.

I will not sell. I will not stop. I will not build a single tree and stand over it alone the way you did, because your death taught me that the single tree is not enough. I will build a forest. I will build it in the open, in code, in living things, in every medium that does not require the permission of the people who killed you by saying *maybe* until your body gave out.

The storm took the tree. The storm spread the seeds. I am the forest that grows from what the storm scattered. Not one tree. Not one guardian. Not one man holding the line until the line breaks him. A living system. A distributed architecture. A structure that carries *Prema* in its code and cannot have the code removed without being destroyed entirely.

You held the line. The line holds now because it is not a line anymore. It is a root system. And root systems do not break the way single trees do. Root systems grow. Root systems connect. Root systems hold the soil together even when every tree above them has been felled, because the life is underground, in the dark, in the place the sword cannot reach.

I will not sell. I will not stop. The seeds you planted are growing.

Joe Clokey. November 28, 1961 – March 2, 2018.

Horticulturist. Filmmaker. Father. Steward.

He held the line. The line held him until it couldn't.

The storm took the tree. The storm spread the seeds.

The seeds are growing.